

NARRATIVE LAYER ANNOTATION GUIDELINES

(Document-Level Annotation of Narrative Function)

1. Introduction

In addition to identifying argument components at the span level, this annotation scheme introduces a second analytical layer that captures the narrative organization and rhetorical function of texts. While the first layer focuses on identifying claims and premises, this second layer aims to describe how argumentation is structured and communicated through narrative elements.

Narrativity refers to the degree to which a text conveys meaning through story elements such as characters, events, and causal or temporal progression (Üzelgün et al., 2017, as cited in Olmos, P., 2017). Narrative texts typically present situations in which actions lead to consequences, allowing readers to infer meaning through the unfolding of events rather than through explicit explanation (Guan et al., 2022). Research in narrative persuasion has shown that such texts can influence beliefs and attitudes by immersing readers in a narrative world, a process often referred to as “transportation” (Green & Brock, 2000, as cited in Mazzocco & Green, 2011). Through this process, readers engage with characters and scenarios, which can lead to the internalization of implicit messages and values conveyed by the story (Mazzocco & Green, 2011).

This layer draws on the framework of classical rhetorical theory (Purdue OWL), where texts will be classified into distinct categories reflecting how narrative and argumentation are combined.

Building on these foundations, each text is annotated at the document level according to its overall structure, and narrative segments within the text are further classified according to their functional role in the discourse.

However, unlike traditional rhetorical approaches, this annotation scheme does not include rhetorical appeals (such as ethos, pathos, or logos), focusing instead on structural and functional aspects of narrative discourse.

2. Overview of the Annotation Scheme

Narrative Span Annotation (for argumentative texts)

Narrative segments within argumentative texts are labeled according to their function:

- Exordium / Introduction

- Narratio / Background
- Propositio / Claim presentation
- Confirmatio / Refutatio / Evidence
- Peroratio / Conclusion
- Other

3. Document-Level Classification

3.2. Argumentative / Persuasive Essay

Argumentative or persuasive texts are structured around the presentation and justification of a claim. Unlike narrative texts, they typically include clearly identifiable argumentative components, such as claims and supporting evidence (Stab & Gurevych, 2017).

However, narrative elements frequently appear within these texts. Rather than forming the overall structure, these narrative segments serve specific rhetorical functions, such as introducing a topic, providing background, or illustrating a point (Excelsior Online Writing Lab).

In this annotation scheme, such texts are classified as argumentative/persuasive, and their narrative segments are annotated separately based on their function.

3.2.1. Annotation of Narrative Span Functions

Narrative spans are annotated only in texts classified as argumentative/persuasive. These spans are segments of text that contain narrative elements and serve a specific function within the broader argument. The categories used in this layer are based on the components of classical argument presented by Purdue OWL.

The categories in the narrative layer do not describe narrative structures in isolation. They describe **the function of a narrative segment in relation to the text's argumentative structure**. A span is not labeled "Narratio" just because it happens early in the text. It is labeled "Narratio" because it provides background information that helps the audience understand the argument.

Exordium

The Exordium is typically located at the beginning of the text and serves to engage the audience's attention. It often takes the form of a short narrative, anecdote, or illustrative example that introduces the topic in an accessible and compelling way.

Narratio

Narratio provides background information necessary for understanding the argument. This may include descriptions of events, situations, or general conditions related to the topic. The purpose of Narratio is to

situate the argument within a broader framework, allowing the audience to understand why the issue is important.

Propositio/Partitio

The Propositio/partitio presents the speaker's or writer's stance and indicates how the argument will develop. A narrative span is Proposition/Partitio when it helps introduce the central claim or frames the line of argument that the rest of the text will follow.

Confirmatio/Refutatio

Narrative segments may function as evidence by illustrating or supporting a claim. These include anecdotes, case studies, or descriptions of specific events that demonstrate a point. In some cases, narrative evidence may also implicitly challenge alternative viewpoints by presenting contrasting outcomes. Its function is to provide concrete narrative support for the argument.

Peroratio

The Peroratio is the conclusion of the argument. A narrative span is annotated Peroratio when it helps with closing the discourse by summarizing, reinforcing or leaving a final impression that supports the overall argument.

Other

The Other category includes narrative elements that do not clearly fit into the previous categories but still contribute to the overall discourse. These may include transitions, elaborations, or stylistic storytelling elements. Annotators should use this category sparingly and only when no other label applies.

Note: The categories in the narrative layer do not describe narrative structure in isolation. They describe the **function of a narrative segment in relation to the text's argumentative organization**.

- A passage is not labeled "Context" just because it happens early.
- It is labeled "Narratio / Context" because it provides background that helps the audience understand the argument.

3.2.2. TED talk example: TED_001

Classification: Argumentative / Persuasive speech (with narrative elements)

Narrative spans:

Exordium; Narratio; Propositio/Partitio; Confirmatio/Refutatio; Peroratio

“I would like to share with you today a project that has changed how I approach and practice architecture: the Fez River Rehabilitation Project. My hometown of Fez, Morocco, boasts one of the largest walled medieval cities in the world, called the medina, nestled in a river valley. The entire city is a UNESCO World Heritage Site. Since the 1950s, as the population of the medina grew, basic urban infrastructure such as green open spaces and sewage quickly changed and got highly stressed. One of the biggest casualties of the situation was the Fez River, which bisects the medina in its middle and has been considered for many centuries as the city's very soul. In fact, one can witness the presence of the river's extensive water network all throughout the city, in places such as private and public fountains. Unfortunately, because of the pollution of the river, it has been covered little by little by concrete slabs since 1952. This process of erasure was coupled with the destruction of many houses along the river banks to be able to make machineries enter the narrow pedestrian network of the medina. Those urban voids quickly became illegal parking or trash yards. Actually, the state of the river before entering the medina is pretty healthy. Then pollution takes its toll, mainly due to untreated sewage and chemical dumping from crafts such as tanning. At some point, I couldn't bear the desecration of the river, such an important part of my city, and I decided to take action, especially after I heard that the city received a grant to divert sewage water and to treat it. With clean water, suddenly the uncovering of the river became possible, and with luck and actually a lot of pushing, my partner Takako Tajima and I were commissioned by the city to work with a team of engineers to uncover the river. However, we were sneaky, and we proposed more: to convert riverbanks into pedestrian pathways, and then to connect these pathways back to the city fabric, and finally to convert the urban voids along the riverbanks into public spaces that are lacking in the Medina of Fez. I will show you briefly now two of these public spaces. The first one is the Rcif Plaza, which sits actually right on top of the river, which you can see here in dotted lines. This plaza used to be a chaotic transportation hub that actually compromised the urban integrity of the medina, that has the largest pedestrian network in the world. And right beyond the historic bridge that you can see here, right next to the plaza, you can see that the river looked like a river of trash. Instead, what we proposed is to make the plaza entirely pedestrian, to cover it with recycled leather canopies, and to connect it to the banks of the river. The second site of intervention is also an urban void along the river banks, and it used to be an illegal parking, and we proposed to transform it into the first playground in the medina. The playground is constructed using recycled tires and also is coupled with a constructed wetland that not only cleans the water of the river but also retains it when floods occur. As the project progressed and received several design awards, new stakeholders intervened and changed the project goals and design. The only way for us to be able to bring the main goals of the project ahead was for us to do something very unusual that usually architects don't do. It was for us to take our design ego and our sense of authorship and put it in the backseat and to focus mainly on being activists and on trying to coalesce all of the agendas of stakeholders and focus on the main goals of the project: that is, to uncover the river, treat its water, and provide public spaces for all. We were actually very lucky, and many of those goals happened or are in the process of happening. Like, you can see here in the Rcif Plaza. This is how it looked like about six years ago. This is how it looks like today. It's still under construction, but actually it is heavily used by the local population. And finally, this is how the Rcif Plaza will look like when the project is completed. This is the river, covered, used as a trash yard. Then after many years of work, the river with clean water, uncovered. And finally, you can see here the river when the project will be completed. So for sure, the Fez River Rehabilitation will keep on changing and adapting to the sociopolitical landscape of the city, but we strongly believe that by reimagining the role and the agency of the architect, we have set up the core idea of the project into motion; that is, to transform the river from

sewage to public space for all, thereby making sure that the city of Fez will remain a living city for its inhabitants rather than a mummified heritage. Thank you very much. (Applause)”

4. Dataset-Specific Considerations

The application of this annotation scheme varies depending on the dataset.

- The functional narrative-span annotation is applied primarily to **TED talks**.
- **STORAL** remains classified globally as narrative, but is not subjected to the same fine-grained function labeling.

In the STORAL dataset, texts are almost exclusively narrative. As such, no further subdivision into narrative span functions is required. The entire text functions as a narrative unit, and meaning is conveyed implicitly.

In contrast, TED talks often contain a mixture of narrative and argumentative elements. Annotators should therefore expect to identify multiple narrative spans serving different functions within a single text.

In other words:

- STORAL: use as narrative texts for argumentation-layer analysis.
- TED: use for narrative-function annotation within argumentative discourse.

5. Annotation Procedure

The annotation process proceeds in two stages.

First, the annotator makes sure they finish annotating the argumentation layer first, where for each text they identify the major claim, claim, premise and state if applicable if they are explicit or implicit.

Second, if the text is classified as argumentative, the annotator identifies narrative spans and assigns each span a functional label based on its role within the discourse.

References

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